several days, dozens more Philippine vessels, including the country's entire coast guard, confronted the Chinese. Though no further ship collisions occurred, worldwide broadcast of video of the maritime confrontation further inflamed tensions.

At this point, on Saturday, September 6, US Indo-Pacific Command, acting directly under orders from US secretary of defense Michele Flournoy, dispatched one guided missile destroyer, the USS *Curtis Wilbur*, and the *Independence*-class littoral combat ship the USS *Charleston* (LCS-18) to the waters off Scarborough, and ordered the USS *John C. Stennis* aircraft carrier to head from its home port in Bremerton, Washington, to Pearl Harbor.[28] In order not to inflame the high tensions, however, the White House and Pentagon decided not to send its Japan-based aircraft carrier, the USS *Gerald Ford*, to the area. Instead, another US guided-missile destroyer, USS *Stethem* (DDG 63), and a mine countermeasures ship, the USS *Patriot* (MCM 7), were ordered to transit the Taiwan Strait. The next day, Beijing announced an air defense identification zone over the entire South China Sea, demanding that all non-Chinese aircraft submit their flight plans to Chinese military authorities and receive clearance to proceed.[29] While the US Air Force and Navy immediately rejected China's authority over the South China Sea, PLAAF and PLANAF aerial patrols increased, and international civilian airliners complied with Beijing's demands.

On Monday, September 8, at approximately 18:30 local time (10:30 Greenwich time; 00:30 Hawaii time; 05:30 eastern time), a US Navy EP-3 surveillance flight out of Japan over the Spratlys was intercepted by a PLAAF J-20 taking off from Fiery Cross Reef, in the same chain. After warning off the EP-3, the J-20 attempted a barrel roll over the American plane. The Chinese pilot sheared off most of the EP-3's tail and left rear stabilizer; the Chinese plane lost a wing and went into an unrecoverable spin into the sea. The EP-3 also could not recover and plunged into the sea, killing all twenty-two Americans aboard.[30] Tragically, the EP-3 was not even supposed to be flying, as the US Navy had intended to replace the fleet with unmanned surveillance drones by 2020, but cost overruns and delays in the drone program led to